

NO SHACKLES TO LEARNING

Over two dozen life-term convicts in the Bhopal Central Jail are pursuing MBA degrees which keeps their minds off the harsh prison routine and also gives them something to look forward to

■ By Ambreesh Mishra

Mahipal Singh Rajput, a 51-year-old agriculturist from the fertile Narmada belt in Hoshangabad, is studying the Reliance Fresh model these days. With masters degrees in economics and geography, his interest in the evolving organised retail of farm products is only natural, but for the fact he is convicted of murder and is serving a life sentence. And the studies are a part of his ongoing MBA programme.

Over two dozen inmates of the Bhopal Central Jail are at present pursuing MBA degrees. Barring one, all of them including a woman, are serving life-terms for murder. The only convict without the tag of Section 302 in the MBA programme is a young man convicted of attempt to murder. Their crimes taught them a lot about life. Now the penal sentence is opening up new avenues of learning.

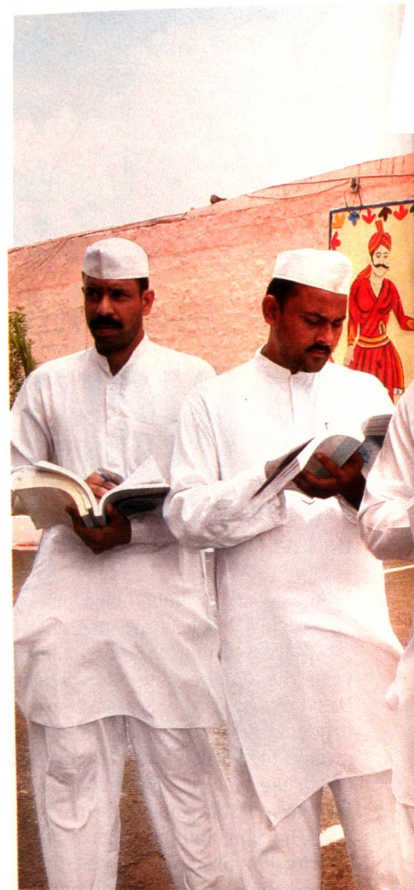
The MBA course in the prison is being run by Bhoj University for Distance Learning, modelled on the lines of the Indira Gandhi National Open University. "The very idea of distance education is to reach out to hitherto untouched groups. Who could be more secluded than the convicts lodged in jails?" says university Vice-Chancellor Dr Kamlakar Singh.

The first three in-

mates, who earned their MBA degrees, were serving short-term sentences and have already been released.

In the current batch, all, without exception, have passed their second semester exams. The convicts have been diligent in their efforts at pursuing the degree. Ever since the jail was recognised as a study centre two years ago, faculty members from Bhoj University hold regular classes here. The prison library now has an impressive array of books on management. The university regularly lends periodicals and papers to the inmates on relevant subjects. Dr. Nafees Ahmed Khan, who teaches management, says, "Their enthusiasm is touching, given the circumstances. To ensure they're not left out on the exposure front, we're trying to evolve a system whereby we can have guest lectures arranged for them in the jail from eminent businesspersons."

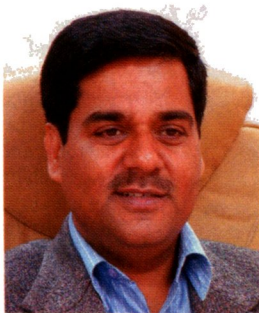
According to Jail Superintendent Purushottam Somkunwar, who is also the brain behind MBA and DCA courses, their efforts to bring over corporate managers as guest or motivational speakers have only been partially successful. "They can't spare time on weekdays while nobody wants to let go of weekends just to give lectures to inmates here," he says. Now, the jail's own labour programme, which mandates six hours of



compulsory work for each inmate sentenced to rigorous imprisonment, could show a way out.

One of the biggest stumbling blocks in their completion of a meaningful MBA programme is that the convicts can neither do internship nor join as management trainees at any organisation. Besides, proper case studies based on field research are impossible due to their confinement. To top it all, there are legal constraints against their use of Internet due to connectivity to the outside world. Realising the odds against conducting a successful MBA programme in a prison, the jail administration is trying to think out of the box.

But for their conviction for murder, the convicts have little in common. Shalini Pathak, an unmarried 28-year-old from Sehore who holds a masters in English literature, was accused of



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DR. KAMLAKAR SINGH, VICE-CHANCELLOR, BHOJ UNIVERSITY